stepped in to end it as quickly as possible. There are also reports of Myanmar naval ships providing food and water to those who had fled by boat and were travelling to what they hoped was a safer part of Rakhine. However, when the refugees arrived near Sittwe (where there is a large refugee camp), the 'army arrived and pushed us back to the sea. We tried to force our way on the shore but they wouldn't let us come on shore'.[42] When they were finally allowed to land they were kept on the beaches, denied aid and beaten by the army.

Elsewhere the main contribution of the army was to urge the Rohingyas to flee the violence. A Kaman Muslim reported: 'I saw five or more army soldiers in front of my fish shop. The whole village was burning. When I saw the soldiers I thought they would help us, but they just shouted at us to get out quickly'.[43] This pattern of the military standing to one side was repeated elsewhere:

> The police and military came and told people to come out of their house, and they said if we didn't we'd all be killed. They said they couldn't provide us with security … And in the presence of the military and police, [the Arakanese] entered our homes and took what they wanted.[44]

Violence by the state security forces carried on after the communal attacks had died down. They attacked those seeking help and continued to treat those displaced with great brutality.[45] The president's initial response was to deny any involvement of the state security forces in the violence.[46] However, the level of violence attracted too much international attention, and by mid-November he was forced to write to Ban Ki-moon to acknowledge that there had been communal violence and to pledge to address problems of forced resettlement and to grant citizenship to the Rohingyas.[47]

The timing of this promise was not accidental—it was released just prior to President Obama's visit to the country and was clearly designed to avoid any embarrassment for his important visitor. But the measure of the insincerity of these promises can be found in the UN Special Rapporteur's report to the UN Security Council in April 2014: he 'saw no improvements in the human rights situation. Instead, as time passes without clear action at the state and national level to address the widespread discrimination and human rights violations occurring there, the situation continues to worsen from an already dire state'.[48]